politics or the entire being of any number of BJP allies anchored in narrower caste groups.

The SP is adapting, rebranding its Gujjar chaupals as PDA chaupals. Dalit-based parties, too, are avoiding caste-specific vocabulary for now, but the ban cuts to the core of their essential practice. Even slogans of caste pride, problematic at one level, change meaning when a Dalit reappropriates a formerly stigmatised name as a form of public self-assertion—e.g. with 'The Great Chamar'.

The issue arose when the Allahabad High Court, hearing a petition, asked why police still use the caste of complainants, accused



and witnesses. The state DGP stated in an affidavit that it helped ease confusion when many share a name, and that the practice had become digitally entrenched with the Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems. He also cited the need to identify caste in cases under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

'A LEGAL FALLACY'

The court was "not impressed" by the gap this logic bore from "professional policing". Relying on caste for identification, Justice Vinod Diwakar said, was a "legal fallacy" in the age of Aadhaar, biometrics and smartphones. Since policing is a state subject, the court said UP had full powers to align its practices with the constitutional aim of a casteless society. It asked that caste columns be erased from police forms, crime portals and notice boards, with parental details filling in if needed. It ordered caste signboards and proclamations in public spaces removed, and advocated changes to the Motor Vehicles Rules and digital regulations to curb caste slogans and online glorification.

Takeaways

- **UP bans all caste-based rallies, drops caste from FIRs, says no glorification**
- **Parties like SP, BSP and BJP's small caste-based allies hardest hit for now**

BLANKET ERASURE

Within a week, the state government issued a sweeping 10-point directive that realised the court's wishes in toto. Proscribing public displays of caste identity in all the forecited realms, it called caste-based rallies a threat to public order and national unity.

With assembly polls due in 2027, smaller outfits with a narrow caste base will be hit the most. Billboard campaigns and community rallies will be harder to stage. BJP allies have signalled their discomfort: the NISHAD Party is seeking SC status for the Nishads, the SBSP is demanding OBC and SC sub-quotas, the Apna Dal (S) is pressing for greater Kurmi representation. Caste-based assertion within the BJP has also been a source of headache for the Yogi Adityanath government, with Thakurs, Kurmis and Lodhs staging 'cultural meets'.

Evidence suggests, for now, that the operations of caste will only move back into subtler, coded spaces—invisibilised only in name. Every other surname will, of course, still proclaim it. ■

▶ GUJARAT

New BJP Chief Has Big Shoes to Fill

The party opts for an OBC face after prolonged haggling

By **Jumana Shah**



EAR TO GROUND New Gujarat BJP chief Jagdish Vishwakarma

IN 1998, WHEN THE BJP'S UNINTERRUPTED REIGN OVER GUJARAT began, 25-year-old Jagdish Panchal had joined the party's booth management team in Ahmedabad's Thakkarbapanagar assembly seat. A day after Dussehra 2025, all of 27 years later, he was elected unopposed as Gujarat's BJP president; the three-time MLA from Ahmedabad's Nikol was the only candidate. It's a two-year-long search that has finally ended with this articulate grassroots figure.

Outgoing president CR Paatil's first three-year term had concluded in 2022, but divergent opinions on a suitable replacement had delayed the succession. The hunt had resumed in full earnest last year after Paatil took over as the Union cabinet minister for water